

In the 2026-27 COVID-19 season scenario projections (Round 20), the US Scenario Modeling Hub considered four intervention scenarios, assessing the impact of annual versus semi-annual vaccination recommendations for high-risk individuals, and business as usual versus optimistic vaccination coverage. A fifth counterfactual scenario, with no intervention during the 2026-2027 season, was modeled for reference.

Key Takeaways

- All vaccination strategies are projected to significantly reduce disease burden compared to no vaccination, irrespective of assumptions about the coverage and frequency of the vaccination campaign.
- Semi-annual vaccination is projected to significantly reduce disease burden compared to annual vaccination, particularly in states with greater concentration of COVID-19 during the summer wave.
- COVID-19 is expected to follow the same seasonal patterns of activity as in recent years, with two waves peaking in September 2026 and January 2027 nationally.

Vaccination Impact on Hospitalizations

Percent and number of hospitalizations averted by immunization

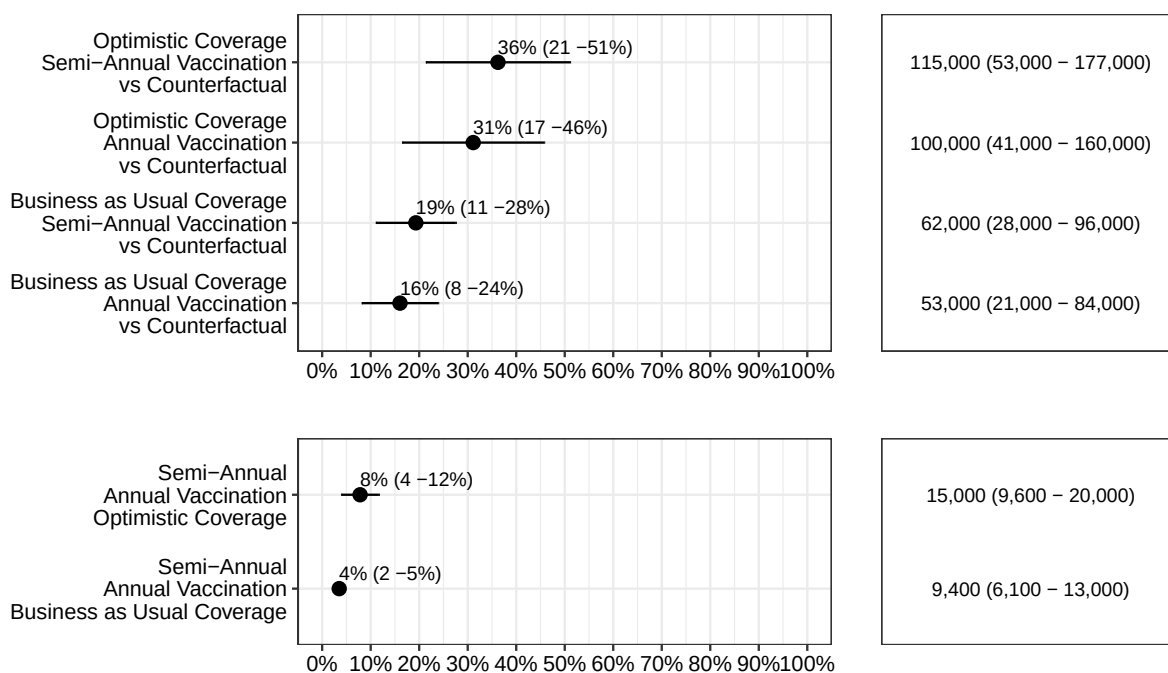


Figure 1. Projected hospitalizations averted by vaccination scenarios in the US, June 07, 2026 to June 05, 2027.

- An annual COVID-19 vaccination campaign with coverage mirroring last year's uptake (business as usual coverage) would avert 16% (95% CI 8%-24%) of hospitalizations and 20% (95% CI 10% - 30%) of deaths, corresponding to 53,000 hospitalizations and 3,700 deaths averted on average, compared to no vaccination.
- An annual COVID-19 vaccination campaign with flu-like coverage (optimistic coverage scenario) would avert 31% (95% CI 17%-46%) of hospitalizations and 36% (95% CI 19%-52%) of deaths, corresponding to 100,000 hospitalizations and 6,300 deaths averted on average, compared to no vaccination.

Season Burden and Trajectory

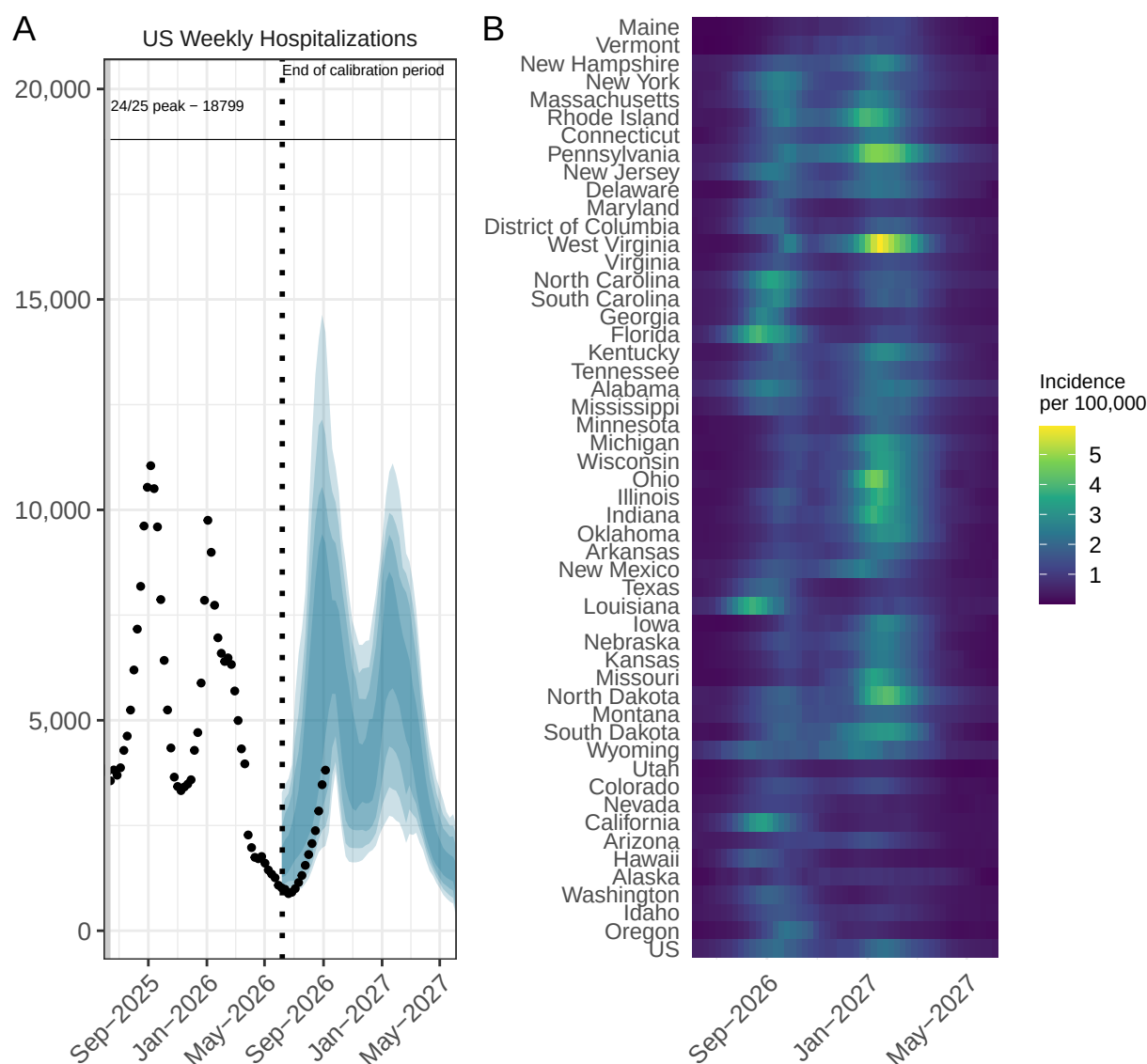


Figure 2. Weekly ensemble projections of COVID-19 hospitalizations in the US, business as usual vaccination coverage and annual vaccination for high-risk individuals, June 07, 2026 to June 05, 2027. A: Time series, from lightest to darkest, shading represents 95%, 90%, 80% and 50% projection intervals (PI). B: Median projected incident hospitalization per 100,000 population, by US State.

- In the business as usual vaccine scenario, we project 240,000 cumulative hospitalization (95% PI 183,000 - 330,000) between June 2026-June 2027 and 11,500 deaths (95% PI 8,000 - 16,300) due to COVID-19, nearly equally spread out between the summer and winter waves.
- Nationally COVID-19 is expected to follow the same seasonal patterns of activity as in recent years, with two waves peaking in September 2026 and January 2027, with continued decline in burden compared to recent years.

The *US COVID-19 Scenario Modeling Hub* aims to produce robust projections to provide real-time actionable modeling evidence to support ongoing public health needs and decision-making. For Round 20, 7 teams contributed projections of the trajectory of COVID-19 from Sunday, June 08, 2025 to June 05, 2027. Detailed scenario descriptions and assumptions are provided [on the SMH GitHub site](https://covid19scenariomodelinghub.org). See covid19scenariomodelinghub.org for more results and details.

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